Behind the Jolly Roger

Myths and Realities of the Golden Age of Piracy (1650–1720)

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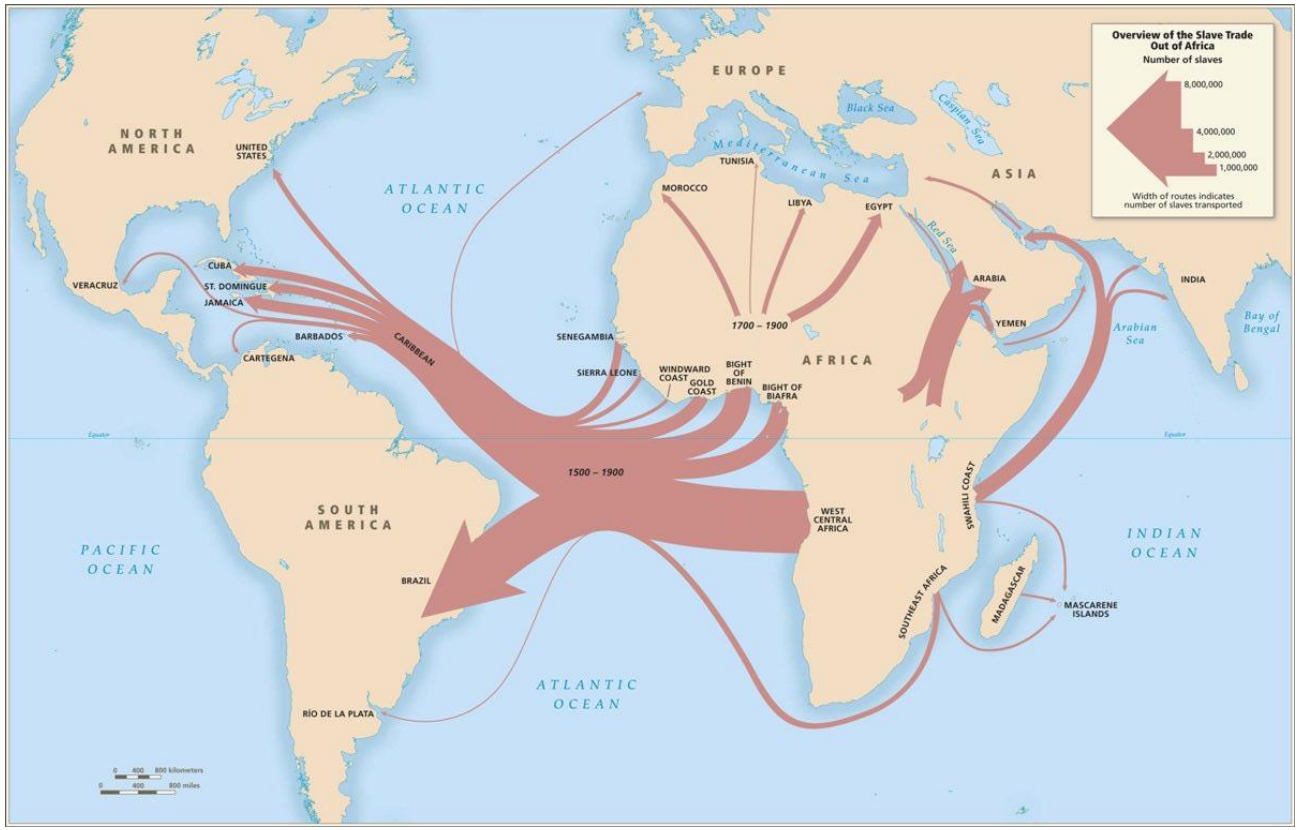
What Was The Golden Age

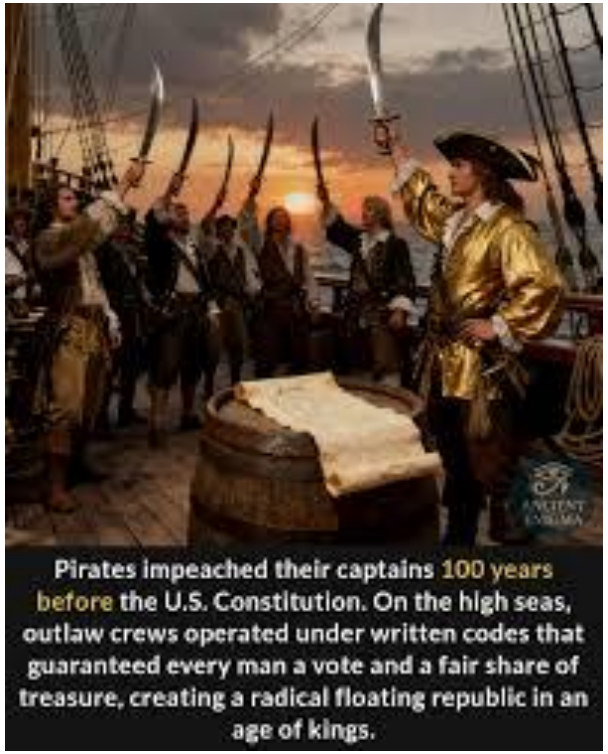


- **The Era:** A 70-year period of unprecedented maritime piracy (1650-1720).
- **The Location:** Centered in the Caribbean, the American colonies, and the Indian Ocean.
- **The Drivers:**
  - Massive growth in valuable colonial trade.
  - Weak naval presence in the "New World."
  - Thousands of unemployed sailors after European wars.

Myth vs Reality

- **Buried Treasure:** Almost never happened. Pirates spent their loot immediately on supplies and entertainment.
- **Walking the Plank:** A fictional invention. Marooning on a deserted island was the actual standard punishment.
- **Eye Patches & Peg Legs:** Often real, but usually due to the lack of medical care rather than fashion.

Democracy On The High Seas



- **The Pirate Code:** Each ship had a written contract signed by every crew member.
- **Voting Rights:** Captains were elected and could be demoted by a majority vote.
- **Checks and Balances:** The Quartermaster was elected to represent the crew's interests and handle the money.

Health and Compensation

Wound Payments in GAoP Pirate Articles

Wound Type	Kidd 1696 Pcs 8	Roberts 1719-22 Pcs 8	Anstis 1721-3 Pcs 8	Philips 1722-4 Pcs 8	Lowther 1721-3 Pounds	Low 1722-4 Pcs 8
Loss of Eye	600					
Loss of Arm	600	800	800	400	150	600
Loss of Leg	600	800	800	400	150	600
Flesh Wound	100					
Loss of Joint				100		
Loss of Finger or Toe	100					

Sources: Kidd - Ed Fox, Doctoral Thesis, 'Piratical Schemes and Contracts': Pirate Articles and Their Society, 1660-1730, University of Exeter, May 2013, p. 310-1; Roberts- Captain Charles Johnson, *A general history of the pirates*, 3rd Edition, p. 232, Anstis - Fox, p. 320; Philips - Johnson, p. 398; Lowther - Johnson, p. 352; Low - Fox, p. 322

Advanced "Insurance": Pirates had a set "payout" for injuries sustained in battle.

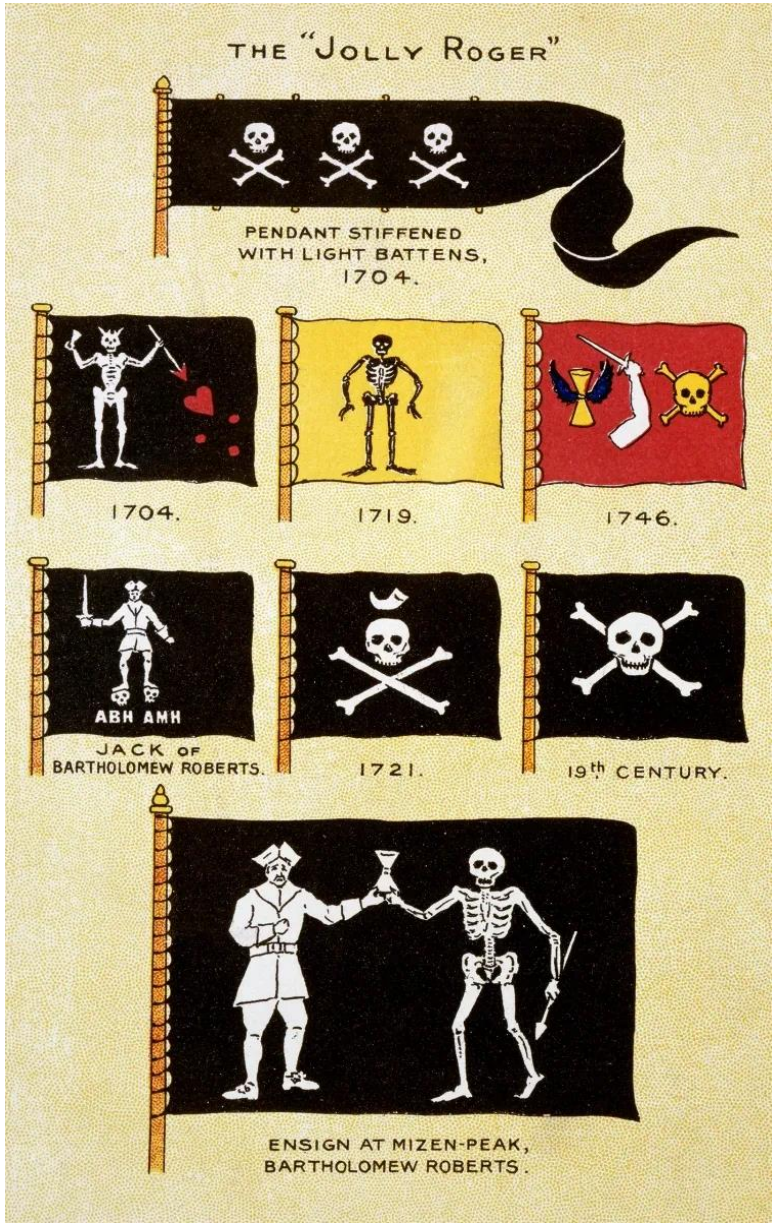
Ship Surgeons: Captured doctors were the most highly valued prisoners.

Blackbeard: The PR Specialist

- **The Name:** Edward Teach.
- **Psychological Warfare:** He wove slow-burning hemp fuses into his beard to appear demonic in battle.
- **His Philosophy:** He preferred to scare ships into surrendering so he wouldn't have to damage the cargo or his own ship.

The Jolley Roger

- **The Black Flag:** Signaled a "polite" invitation to surrender. If the ship stopped, no one was harmed.
- **The Red Flag:** Known as the "Bloody Red," it meant no mercy would be shown and everyone would be killed.
- **Design:** Each captain had a unique design to identify themselves to their victims.



Why The Era Ended

- **The Royal Navy:** Britain and other nations sent massive fleets to hunt pirates down.
- **The King’s Pardon:** Many pirates accepted "Acts of Grace"—immunity in exchange for retiring.
- **Better Laws:** Piracy became "Enemy of All Mankind", allowing any nation to hang them.

Connection To Modern Business

- **Disruption:** Pirates were the original 'disruptors' of a stale industry.
- **Agile Management:** Small teams, flat hierarchy, and quick pivots.
- **Incentive Alignment:** Every 'employee' had a literal stake in the company's success.

Conclusion and Questions

- Pirates: Outlaws or Innovators?
- Legacy in Pop Culture
- Questions?